

Supplementary materials for: Palaeoclimatic constraints behind the
Great American Biotic Interchange: insights from eco-evolutionary
simulations

Lucas Buffan¹, Adrián Castro Insua², Fabien L. Condamine¹, Sara Varela²

Affiliations:

¹ Institut des Sciences de l'Evolution de Montpellier, Université de Montpellier, CNRS, IRD, Place Eugène Bataillon, 34095 Montpellier cedex 5, France.

² Centro de Investigación Mariña, Departamento de Ecoloxía e Bioloxía Animal, Universidade de Vigo, Campus Lagoas-Marcosende, 36310 Vigo, Spain

Method details

Beforehand, it has to be noticed that, across the entire study, “North America” actually refers to the current North and Central American continents. The delimitation between North and South America was represented as a straight line connecting two points located along the eastern and western coasts of present Panama (-82.882°lon , 7.138°lat and -81.369°lon and 9.008°lat).

Palaeoclimate data

We used the spatio-temporal terrestrial palaeoclimate series from the PALEO-PGEM atmosphere-ocean general circulation model [1], covering the last 5 Myrs with a $1 \times 1^\circ$ spatial resolution [2]. For the scope of this work, we used two bioclimatic variables: mean annual temperature (MAT, BIO1) and mean annual precipitation (MAP, BIO12). To avoid reaching an overkillingly-high number of simulation steps, we reduced the temporal resolution of the climate simulations from a 1000-years to a 10,000-years time step.

Additionally, in order to discriminate simulations on the basis of the biome the initial species starts in, we reclassified monthly palaeoclimate layers for our starting time ($t = 5$ Myrs) according to Köppen-Geiger broad climate types [3]. This classification divides the world into five broad climatic regions: Polar, Cold, Temperate, Arid and Tropical.

Simulation model and modelling schemes

We performed our spatially-explicit simulations of biodiversity using the General Engine for Eco-Evolutionary SImulationS, gen3sis, v1.5.11 [4]. Simulations, moving forward-in-time with a 10ky time step, tracked the radiation of a clade arising from a single ancestral population, either originating in North or in South America, throughout the last 5 Myr. In gen3sis, virtual species are made up with a set of individual populations evolving independently, following a set of four rules: dispersal, speciation, environmental filtering and trait evolution. All simulation scenarios that we implemented only differed on the last rule (trait evolution), the first three being common to all models (or at least partly).

We elaborated a gridded landscape made up with the two time-series of the aforementioned palaeoclimatic layers. Within this landscape, virtual species, made up with populations, inhabited a set of connected cells. At each time step, populations could disperse to the surrounding cells with an intensity sampled in a Weibull distribution (of shape and scale respectively termed ϕ and ψ). If, by chance, two populations happened to be disconnected, they would accumulate divergence as long as they get disconnected, at a rate ruled by a divergence factor, here set to 0.05. Once passed a divergence threshold (S), speciation would occur. Thus, the only mode of speciation allowed by gen3sis is allopatry.

As our goal was to evaluate the extent to which palaeoclimate change may have shaped the unequal success of North American taxa establishing southwards compared to South American taxa establishing northwards, local climate was set as the only constraint for a population to maintain in a given cell. Each species was therefore assigned a two-dimensional climatic niche, one axis corresponding to temperature suitability and the other to precipitation suitability. The abundance of a species along an environmental gradient was ruled by two parameters – that we also call traits – a population- and species-specific optimum (resp. $P_{k,l}$ and $T_{k,l}$ for the precipitation and temperature optima of the population k of the species l) and a breadth (or tolerance) (resp. ω_P and ω_T ; within a simulation, breadths were shared across populations and species). A population could maintain in a given cell only if the difference between its optima and local climate (both temperature and precipitation) was below its breadths. Therefore, given a site i with local precipitation and temperature at time t being $P_i(t)$ and $T_i(t)$, this translates in

$$\begin{cases} |P_i(t) - P_{k,l}| < \omega_P \\ |T_i(t) - T_{k,l}| < \omega_T \end{cases}$$

Each simulation started with a single ancestral species. The range of this ancestral species was randomly selected within the desired ancestral area (*i.e.*, North or South America). To avoid oversampling high latitudes, we merged the ancestral landscape with the centroids of an equal-area grid ($\sim 100\text{km}$ spacing) generated using the R package *h3jsr* [5]. We then sampled a centroid at random and retrieved the corresponding cell in our landscape. To reduce the probability of initial crash, the temperature and/or precipitation optima parameter of the ancestor were set to those of the local environment.

A total of 500 replicates was made under each modelling scheme (detailed in the next paragraph), both with North and South America as ancestral area. Across replicates, we varied 6 key parameters: (1) the divergence threshold above which speciation occurred (S , range = $[1, 3]$), (2) the rate of environmental niche evolution – only in models where we allowed climatic niche to evolve (σ_e , $[0.005, 0.15]$), (3) the shape (ϕ , $[0.5, 3]$) and (4) scale (ψ , $[0.1, 1]$) of the Weibull distribution acting as a dispersal kernel, (5) the strength of environmental filtering (*i.e.*, niche breadth) for temperature (ω_T , $[0.01, 0.1]$) and (6) precipitation (ω_P , $[0.05, 0.3]$). As done by many authors, we ensured an even sampling of the resulting multidimensional parameter space via a quasirandom sampling technique relying on Sobol’ sequences [6,7]. Parameter ranges were determined on the basis of a literature review, allowing to assess their biological relevance, and were further adjusted in order to limit the prevalence of crashing simulations.

We implemented various simulation scenarios where we modulated the ability of species to cope with climate change, and thus, the generalist vs. specialist nature of the simulated species. In the full-adaptationist model ($M1$, generalist), climatic optima ($P_{k,l}$ and $T_{k,l}$) were able to evolve in the direction of local climate change. To isolate the effect of a single environmental covariate on the resulting simulated biodiversity pattern, alternative versions of this model consisted of either removing the temperature ($M2$) or the precipitation ($M3$) constraint on species ecology. Besides, we also implemented a zero-adaptationist model ($M0$, specialist), where niche optima could not evolve and were therefore held constant (to their initial value) across all simulations.

Last, it is important to notice that, since the palaeoclimate reconstructions that we used ignored tectonic plate motion – a reasonable assumption for a 5-Myr time frame – continental position in our landscapes was held constant across simulations. Therefore, in that framework, changes in connectivity between North and South America could only arise from the environment.

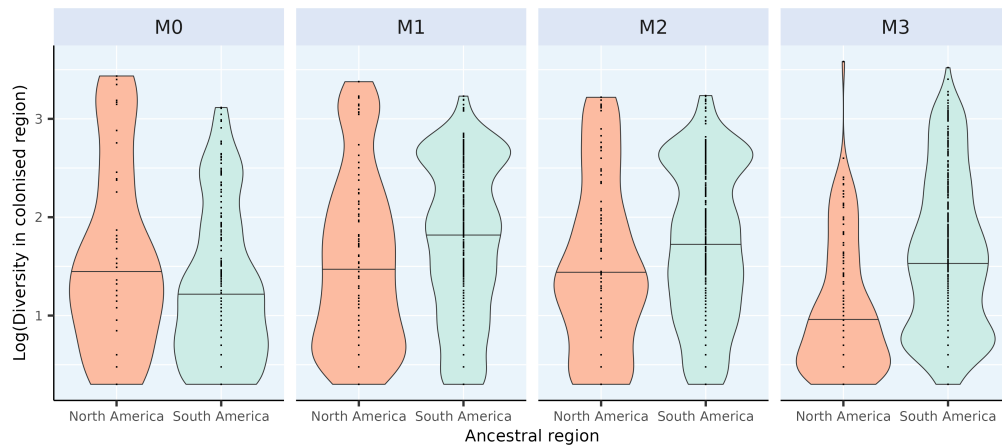
Postprocessing and quantifications

At every time step and for each run of each simulation, we used a function released by Skeels et al. [7] to save presence-absence matrices. Given a time t , those matrices stored on their columns the presence of each simulated species that have existed from the onset of the simulation to t within each cell of the landscape (rows of the matrix) as a binary variable – 1: the species inhabits that cell, 0: it does not.

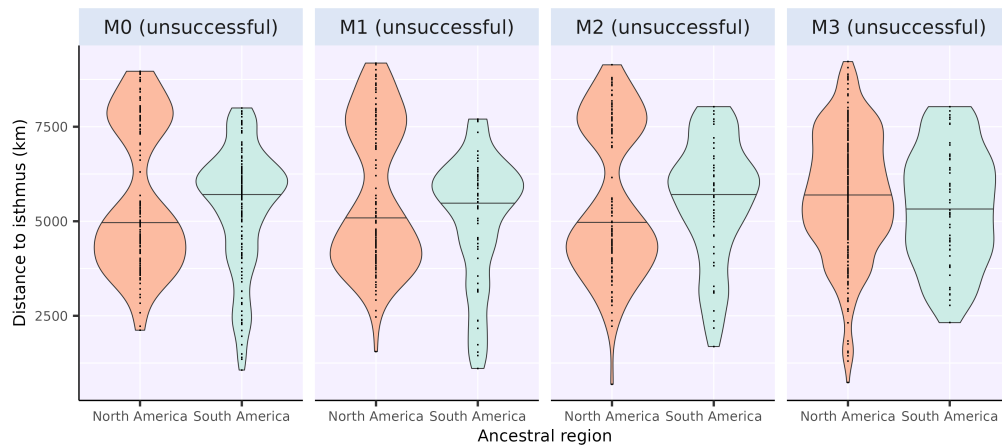
Given a batch of simulations, after discarding those that crashed – *i.e.*, that lead to no living representative – we quantified four metrics reflecting the occurrence, magnitude and efficiency of an eventual transcontinental exchange based on the presence-absence matrix of the last time step of each successful run (hereafter called t_{end}). First, we assessed the exchange success, a binary variable set to one if at least one pixel of the area to colonise (hereafter called $\mathcal{A}_{col}$, *e.g.*, South America if the simulation started in North America) recorded a presence. Then, we recorded the biome in which the initial ancestor occurs (*i.e.*, Tropical, Arid, Temperate, Cold, Polar) as well as the distance of this initial ancestor to a point arbitrarily located on the zone of the isthmus of Panama, (-84°lon , 10°lat). Last, in the case of a successful exchange, we quantified the number of virtual taxa recorded in $\mathcal{A}_{col}$ at t_{end} and the proportion of $\mathcal{A}_{col}$ actually colonised at t_{end} as the ratio between the number of cells occupied by the colonisers and the total number of available cells (*i.e.*, surface of $\mathcal{A}_{col}$).

Supplementary figures

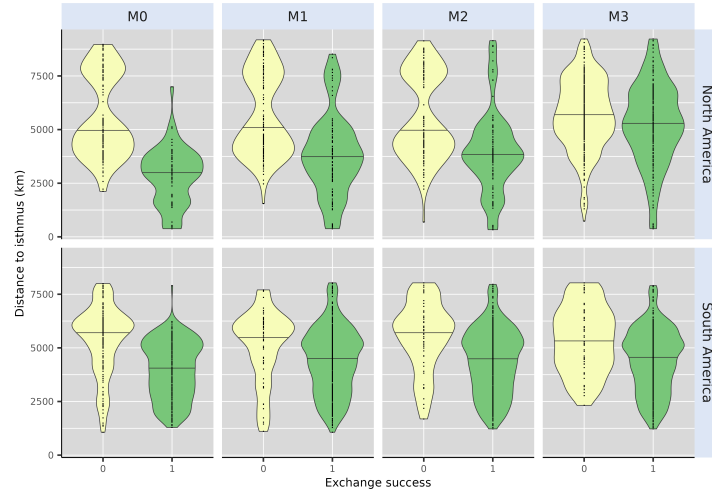
All across the study, metrics computed out of simulations starting in North America are shown in coral red, and those starting in South America in cyan.



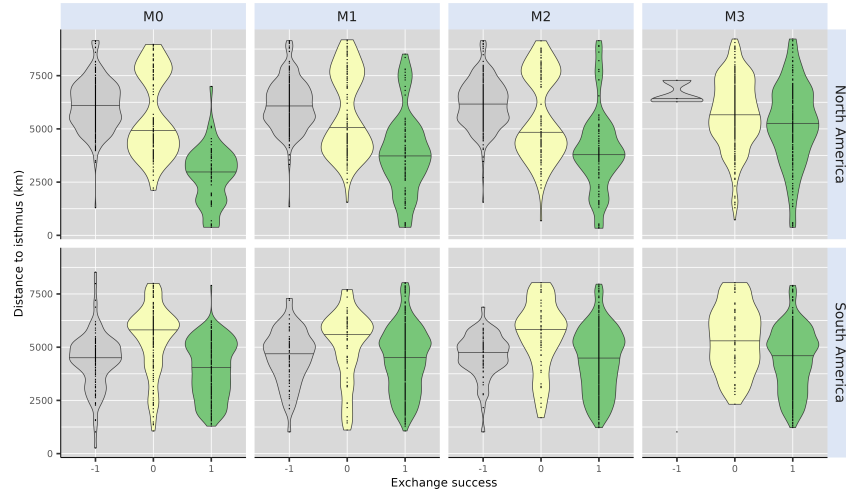
Supp.Figure 1: Diversity in the colonised area following a successful interchange (decimal log scale).



Supp.Figure 2: Distance to the isthmus for non-successful simulations – *i.e.*, that did not result in a significant interchange.



Supp. Figure 3: Comparison of the initial distance to the isthmus between successful and unsuccessful simulations of each of our four models, either starting from North (top) or South (bottom) America. Successful simulations (*Exchange Success* = 1) are displayed in green, whereas unsuccessful simulations (*Exchange Success* = 0) are displayed in yellow.



Supp. Figure 4: Comparison of the initial distance to the isthmus between successful and unsuccessful simulations of each of our four models including simulations that crashed (*i.e.*, resulted in no living representative at the final time step), either starting from North (top) or South (bottom) America. Successful simulations (*Exchange Success* = 1) are displayed in green, unsuccessful simulations (*Exchange Success* = 0) in yellow and simulation that crashed (*Exchange Success* = -1) in grey.

Supplementary tables

Supp.Table 1: Fixed parameter values for gen3sis simulations.

Name	Value	Description
divergence_factor	0.05	How much divergence disconnected populations accumulate across iterations
max_species	10000.00	Maximum number of simulated species a simulation can handle (if falls above, the simulation crashes)
max_coex_species	1000.00	Cell carrying capacity
start_species	1.00	Number of species to start with
init_ab	500.00	Initial abundance of the start species
grid_cell_distance	111.00	Distance (in km) between two grid cells of the landscape at the equator

Supplementary references

1. Holden PB, Edwards NR, Rangel TF, Pereira EB, Tran GT, Wilkinson RD. 2019 PALEO-PGEM v1.0: A statistical emulator of pliocene–pleistocene climate. *Geoscientific Model Development* **12**, 5137–5155. (doi:<https://doi.org/10.5194/gmd-12-5137-2019>)
2. Barreto E, Holden PB, Edwards NR, Rangel TF. 2023 PALEO-PGEM-Series: A spatial time series of the global climate over the last 5 million years (Plio-Pleistocene). *Global Ecology and Biogeography* **32**, 1034–1045. (doi:[10.1111/geb.13683](https://doi.org/10.1111/geb.13683))
3. Galván S, Gamboa S, Varela S. 2023 [Köppen Geiger climatic classification for R users](#).
4. Hagen O, Flück B, Fopp F, Cabral JS, Hartig F, Pontarp M, Rangel TF, Pellissier L. 2021 gen3sis: A general engine for eco-evolutionary simulations of the processes that shape Earth’s biodiversity. *PLOS Biology* **19**, e3001340. (doi:[10.1371/journal.pbio.3001340](https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pbio.3001340))
5. O’Brien L. 2023 *h3jsr: Access uber’s H3 library*. See <https://CRAN.R-project.org/package=h3jsr>.
6. Hagen O, Skeels A, Onstein RE, Jetz W, Pellissier L. 2021 Earth history events shaped the evolution of uneven biodiversity across tropical moist forests. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* **118**, e2026347118. (doi:[10.1073/pnas.2026347118](https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2026347118))
7. Skeels A *et al.* 2023 Paleoenvironments shaped the exchange of terrestrial vertebrates across wallace’s line. *Science* **381**, 86–92. (doi:[10.1126/science.adf7122](https://doi.org/10.1126/science.adf7122))